# You got an email from PoL Microscopy Data Management — what does it mean?

A short guide for users of the PoL Microscopy instruments and processing computers. It explains the emails, what you have to do, and how to solve common problems.

In short Which email did I get? Where my data must be Reading the email Troubleshooting Questions

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**In short**

1. Storage on the microscope and processing computers is **temporary**. Data is deleted automatically after a set time.
2. You are warned by email **before** anything is deleted. Every email tells you the **exact deletion date**.
3. Copy everything you want to keep to **your own storage** (group share, project storage, ...) before that date.
4. Keep your data in the right place — **your email-named folder** (and, on processing computers, inside a **PROJECT** folder).
5. Deleted data **cannot be restored**.

## Which email did I get?

Every email starts with `PoL CleanUp - <computer name>:`, so you always know which computer it is about. Find your email by its subject:

`… N file(s) (… GB) due for deletion on 18 Nov 2026`
`… N PROJECT folder(s) (… GB) due for deletion on 18 Nov 2026`

A **warning**. The listed data will be deleted on that date. You get reminders as the date comes closer (e.g. 2 weeks, 1 week, 3 days and 1 day before).

**→ Copy the data you want to keep to your own storage before the date. Data you don’t need: nothing to do.**

`… N file(s) have exceeded the …-day retention period`
`… N PROJECT folder(s) have reached the end of their retention period`

A **final notice**: this data is already past its time and will be deleted on the next run, usually the next day.

**→ Copy anything you still need today.**

`… Done — N file(s) deleted`
`… N PROJECT folder(s) deleted (… GB)`

The data has been **deleted**. The attached list shows exactly which files.

**→ Nothing to do. If something important was deleted, contact us — but deleted data cannot be restored.**

`… File issue(s) in your PROJECTS folder`

Some of your files are **not in the right place** (processing computers): they are not inside a `PROJECT` folder. See Where my data must be.

**→ Move these files into a PROJECT folder (e.g. `PROJECT1`), or copy them to your own storage and remove them.**

`[Cleanup TEST - …] …`

Any subject starting with `[Cleanup TEST` is a **test** by the facility — it checks that emails reach you. Nothing was deleted, and the dates in it are only an example.

**→ Nothing to do.**

One email can contain several of these at once, e.g. “1 PROJECT folder deleted” plus a warning for another folder plus file issues.

## Where my data must be

On every computer there is a folder called `PROJECTS`. Inside it, **your** folder is named exactly like your email address. That name is how the system knows whom to email.

### On a microscope (acquisition) computer

Everything goes into your email-named folder. Inside it, you can organise your data however you like. Each file is deleted after the set time (e.g. 42 days after it was last changed).

✔ Right

```
D:\PROJECTS\
└── anna.muster@tu-dresden.de\
    ├── 2026-10-20_zebrafish\
    │   └── Position1\T0001.czi
    └── 2026-11-02_test\…
```

✘ Wrong

```
D:\
├── Anna\…                ← not in PROJECTS
└── PROJECTS\
    ├── anna.muster\…     ← no email address
    └── anna.muster@tu-dresden\…
                          ← ".de" missing
```

### On a processing computer

Inside your email-named folder, every project gets its own `PROJECT` folder: `PROJECT0`, `PROJECT1`, `PROJECT2`, … A PROJECT folder is kept as a whole for a set time (e.g. at least 90 days after it was created, and 42 days after the last change inside it), then the whole folder is deleted.

✔ Right

```
P:\PROJECTS\
└── anna.muster@tu-dresden.de\
    ├── PROJECT1\
    │   ├── raw\…
    │   └── analysis\…
    └── PROJECT2\…
```

✘ Wrong — reported as "file issue"

```
P:\PROJECTS\
└── anna.muster@tu-dresden.de\
    ├── results.xlsx      ← loose file
    ├── fiji-windows-x64.exe
    ├── my_analysis\…     ← not a PROJECT
    └── PROJECT_1\…       ← underscore
```

### Which PROJECT folder names work?

| FOLDER NAME | COUNTS AS PROJECT FOLDER? |
| --- | --- |
| `PROJECT1`, `PROJECT0`, `PROJECT12` | ✔ Yes |
| `project1`, `Project2` | ✔ Yes (capitalisation doesn't matter) |
| `PROJECT_1`, `PROJECT 1`, `PROJECT-1` | ✘ No — no space, dash or underscore |
| `PROJECT1_old`, `PROJECT1 (copy)` | ✘ No — nothing after the number |
| `PROJECT`, `Projects`, `MyProject1` | ✘ No — "PROJECT" followed directly by a number |

**Why does it matter?** Files outside a PROJECT folder are not looked after: you get a "file issue" reminder instead of a proper deletion schedule, and such data is **not safe** on the computer and could be deleted.

**Typo in your folder name = no emails.** If your folder isn't named exactly like your email address, the system can't warn you — your data is still cleaned up. Please check the spelling, including the domain (e.g. `@tu-dresden.de`, `@mpi-cbg.de`).

## Reading the email

A typical warning looks like this (numbers explained below):

**Subject:** PoL CleanUp - LSM980: 2 PROJECT folder(s) (85.2 GB) due for deletion on 6 Nov 2026
**Attachment:** 📎 PoL_CleanUp_LSM980_full_list_2026-11-03.html (6)

**Dear LSM980 user,**

2 PROJECT folders (85.2 GB) will be deleted soon, starting 6 Nov 2026. Please move any data you want to keep.

Some of your files are not located in the correct PROJECT folder. Please move their contents into a PROJECT folder, as data kept outside a PROJECT folder is not safe and could be deleted. (1)

**File issue(s)**
The following item(s) … are located outside of a PROJECT folder:

```
results.xlsx (file, 24.1 KB)
my_analysis (folder, 3.2 GB)
```

… and 3 more item(s) — all are listed in the attached file

A PROJECT folder is currently kept for at least 90 days after it was created.

**Your PROJECT folders**

Not scheduled for deletion | upcoming (≤ 21 days) | due (< 1 week) (2)

| | FOLDER / BIGGEST FILES | AGE | LAST CHANGE | SIZE | DELETION |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|
|  | **P:\PROJECTS\anna.muster@tu-dresden.de** | | 212 file(s) | 160.4 GB | 85.2 GB due or upcoming |
|  | **PROJECT2** (3) | 13 weeks (92 days) | 12 Sep 2026 | 48.0 GB | 6 Nov 2026 (in 3 days) (4) **Due** |
| | raw/stack_0012.czi (5) | | | 4.1 GB | |
| | … and 41 more file(s) in this folder (39.2 GB) | | | | |
|  | **PROJECT3** | 12 weeks (84 days) | 20 Sep 2026 | 37.2 GB | 17 Nov 2026 (in 14 days) **Upcoming** |
|  | **PROJECT4** | 3 weeks (21 days) | 1 Nov 2026 | 72.0 GB | 1 Feb 2027 (in 90 days) **Not scheduled for deletion** |

1. **File issues** (processing computers): files that are not in a PROJECT folder. At most 5 are shown; the attachment lists all of them.
2. **Colours:** green = not scheduled for deletion yet · orange = upcoming (the warning period has started) · red = due, deleted in less than a week.
3. **One row per folder** — on processing computers per PROJECT folder, on microscope computers per folder in your email folder, most urgent first.
4. **Deletion date** with a countdown. If a folder's files have different dates, you see a range, e.g. "4–6 Nov 2026 (in 1–3 days)".
5. **The biggest files** of that folder (up to 5), so you see where most of the space is.
6. **The attachment** lists **every** file with its deletion date (and, after a deletion, the files that were deleted). It opens in any web browser. Long names are shortened in the email, but complete in the attachment.

### The colours

**Not scheduled for deletion**
Nothing to do yet.

**Upcoming**
The warning period has started. Plan to copy what you need.

**Due (< 1 week)**
Deleted within a week. Copy now.

### How the dates are calculated

- **Microscope computers:** each file is deleted a set number of days after it was **last changed** (its "modified" date). Opening or viewing a file does not change that date.
- **Processing computers:** a PROJECT folder is kept at least a set time after it was **created**, and also a set time after the **last change** to anything inside it — whichever is later. Working in a project keeps it alive.
- The exact periods can differ between computers. **The date in your email is always the real one.**
- Normally, nothing is deleted sooner than 2 weeks after your first warning about it.

## Troubleshooting

**“I moved my data to another folder on the same computer — it was still deleted.”**

Moving data around *on the computer* doesn’t keep it. Copy it to **your own storage** (group share, project storage, external drive) before the deletion date.

**“My folder name was slightly different, so I never got an email.”**

The folder must be named exactly like your email address, e.g. `anna.muster@tu-dresden.de`. A typo, a missing “.de” or just your name means the system can’t reach you.

**“I put my files directly in my email folder on the processing computer.”**

On processing computers, data belongs in a PROJECT folder (`PROJECT1`, `PROJECT2`, …). Loose files and other folders are reported as “file issues” and are not looked after.

**“I named my folder PROJECT_1 / Project 1 / PROJECT1_final.”**

Only “PROJECT” followed directly by a number counts (capitalisation doesn’t matter). See the table above.

**“I copied old data onto the computer and it got a warning right away.”**

A copy often keeps the original “modified” date of the files, so old data counts as old even if you copied it today. You will normally still get about 2 weeks’ notice before such data is deleted.

## Questions

**Can deleted data be restored?**

No. Once the deletion email has arrived, the data is gone from that computer. This is why you are warned several times before.

**Why do I get several emails about the same data?**

You get reminders as the deletion date comes closer (for example 2 weeks, 1 week, 3 days and 1 day before). Each reminder is sent only once.

**I don’t use this computer — why do I get emails?**

Someone created a folder with your email address on it. Check the folder path in the email, and tell us if it isn’t yours.

**How do I open the attachment?**

It is a small web page (`.html`). Open it with any browser — double-click it, or save it and open it. It lists every file with its size and deletion date.

**Some small files aren’t listed — why?**

Very small files (e.g. system files like `.DS_Store` or `Thumbs.db`) are left out of the emails to keep them readable. They follow the same schedule.

**I need more time for my data.**

Contact us before the deletion date — we’ll find a solution.

**Questions or problems?** Write to pol_microscopy@tu-dresden.de — please mention the computer name from the email subject.

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